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Research

This Month in Geopolitics: May 2026

Key events, themes and trends to watch in the month ahead

May 2026

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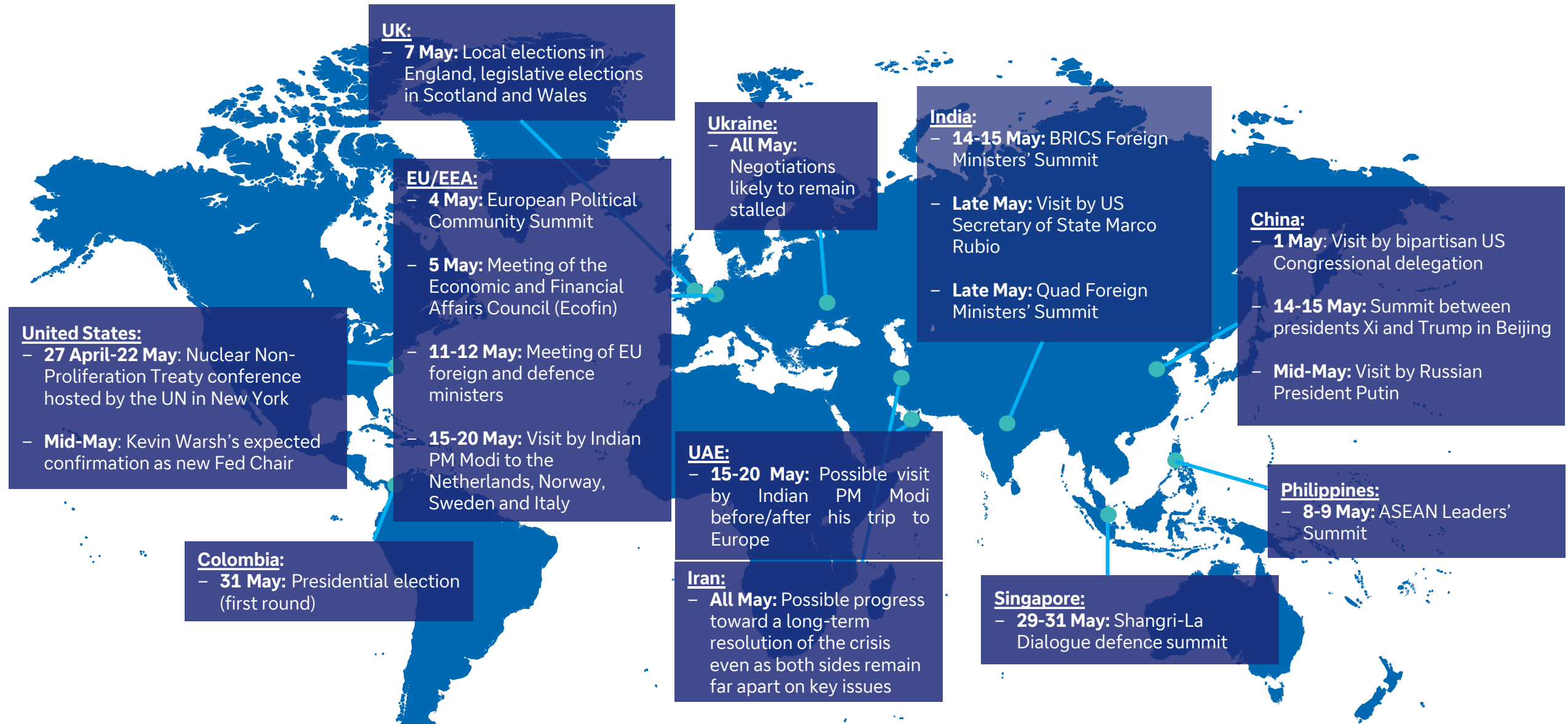
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IMPORTANT RESEARCH DISCLOSURES LOCATED IN APPENDIX 1.

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At a Glance: Geopolitical events to watch in May 2026

Our monthly Look-Ahead covers a *non-exhaustive* list of key events, issues and themes to watch in the month ahead. The below map intends to serve as an executive summary, providing a list of the issues at a glance. These are covered in more detail in subsequent slides.



Source: Deutsche Bank

In focus for May: The war in Iran and the Xi-Trump summit in Beijing



The War in Iran: An End in Sight?

Key points of contention remain between the two sides, including Iran's nuclear programme, the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and sanctions relief. The US rejection of Iran's latest peace proposal on 1 May, and Iran's warning of possible military action on 4 May, underscored that both sides remain far apart on key issues. But despite the precarious ceasefire, the probability of a longer-term resolution is assessed to be strong. The US is facing diminishing returns and increasing domestic and international pressure as the economic consequences of the crisis grow, which will likely push the administration towards a settlement.

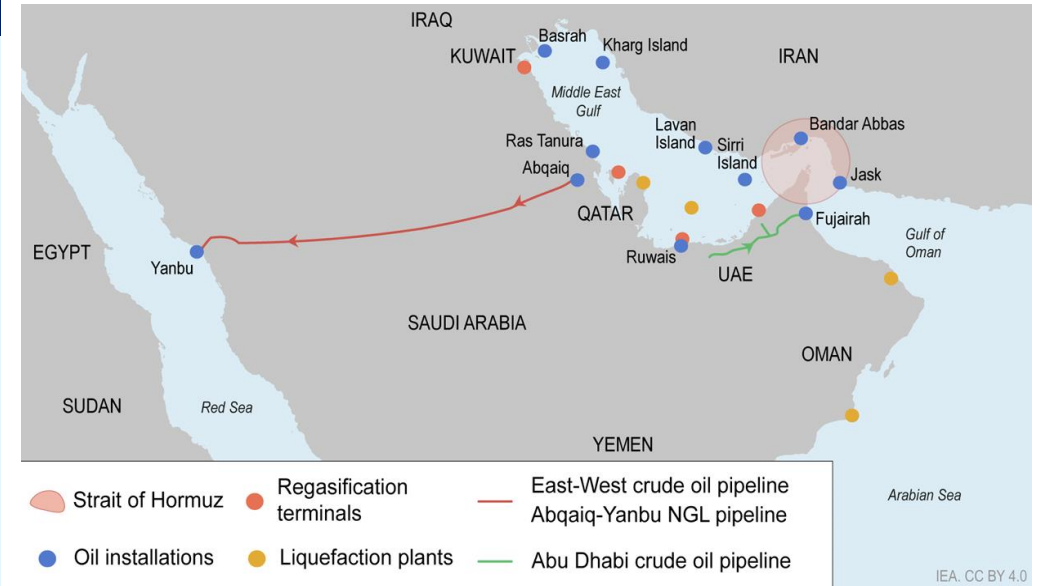
This conflict is a transformative event for the Middle East, shattering the previous geopolitical equilibrium and creating a new, unpredictable reality – as illustrated by the UAE's decision to leave OPEC on 1 May. Iran is expected to emerge with enhanced influence, while Gulf states will likely re-evaluate their security posture and further diversify their international relationships beyond the United States. Post-conflict normalization and economic recovery will be a lengthy process, likely taking months. Rebuilding critical infrastructure like Qatar's Ras Laffan gas field and restoring confidence for shipping through the Strait of Hormuz – which remains far below pre-war levels (see chart) will take considerable time, with knock-on effects like inflation likely lasting well into the second half of 2026.

Xi-Trump Summit: Toward a Tactical Deal

Barring a significant escalation in the Iran war, the summit between presidents Xi and Trump on 14-15 May will likely go ahead as planned – and deliver a package of tactical agreements. The meeting will likely coalesce around limited, but potentially more achievable, deliverables. These could include Chinese commitments to purchase up to 500 Boeing jets, US soybeans and energy, as well as Chinese requests for the US to ease export controls, including on chips and aircraft engine parts. Both sides could also agree to set up a 'Board of Trade' to increase bilateral trade in non-sensitive areas. Progress on a proposed 'Board of Investment' could be more limited owing to mutual national security concerns linked to investment, although the summit could still deliver a small number of investment deals.

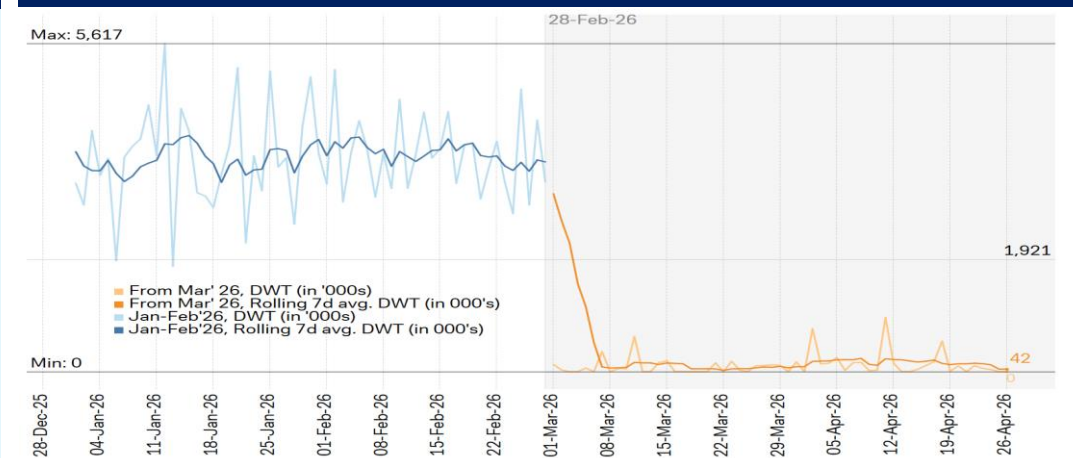
Despite recent [signs of friction](#) over Iran, both sides appear to be prioritizing bilateral stability. The threshold for another summit deferral is likely high. But a breakdown of the US-Iran ceasefire and a return to fighting would be a notable downside risk, increasing the probability of another summit delay or even a cancellation.

Oil and gas infrastructure in the Gulf



Source: International Energy Agency

Tanker activity exiting the Strait of Hormuz (in DWT'000s)



Source: dbDataInsights

Other key events, issues and themes to watch in May 2026

Listed in chronological order



Ukraine war (all May)

Negotiations for a ceasefire in Ukraine will likely remain stalled during May. While there is ongoing diplomatic activity, no new rounds of ceasefire talks are publicly scheduled for May or June. Ukrainian President Zelenskyy has stated that the US wants Russia and Ukraine to reach a peace agreement by June. However, the specifics of how this would manifest in terms of scheduled meetings are unclear.

While a ceasefire over the coming months is far from guaranteed, even credible steps toward a deal would have implications for markets. These could include a possible easing of some sanctions on Russia, the potential for increased Ukrainian agriculture exports, and for enabling reconstruction – with implications for investments in minerals, gas infrastructure, technology, city reconstruction, data centres and artificial intelligence.

Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty conference (27 April – 22 May)

The UN-sponsored conference in New York is taking place against the backdrop of rising geopolitical tensions and the prospect of a new nuclear arms race. The expiry of the New START Treaty on 5 February marked the end of the last binding nuclear arms control agreement between the US and Russia. Both countries retain the world’s largest nuclear warhead inventories (see chart). While these have shrunk slightly in recent years, the unravelling of the New START deal could reignite nuclear competition.

Meanwhile, China is pursuing a significant expansion of its nuclear stockpile. There is little evidence to suggest that either the New York conference or other recent initiatives – including a proposal by President Trump for a new arms control treaty between China, Russia and the US – are likely to translate into binding agreements in the near term.

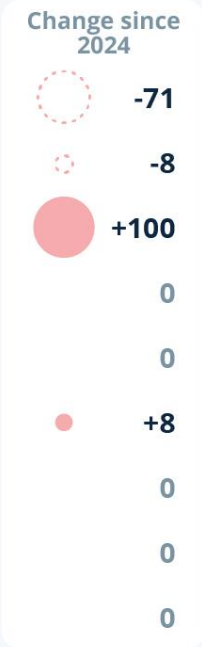
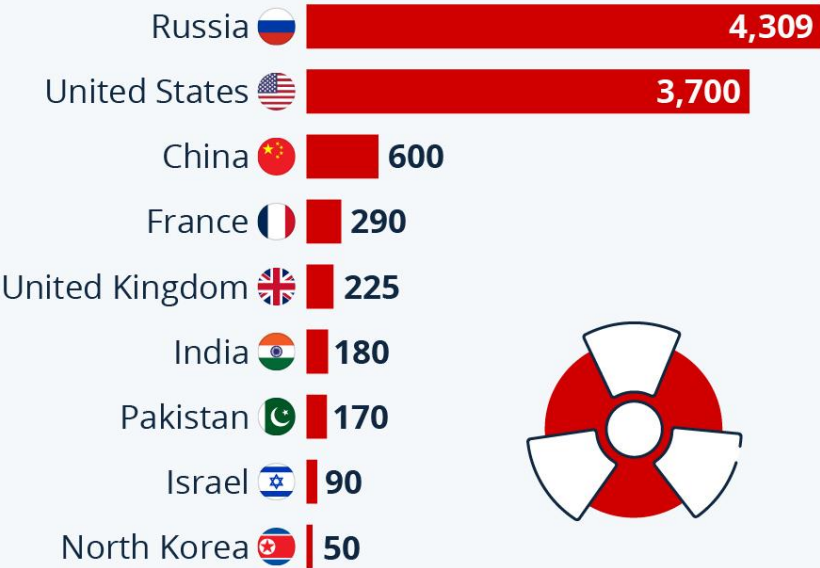
Bipartisan US Congressional delegation visiting China (1 May onward)

The reported visit reflects continued engagement and relative stability in China-US ties ahead of the Xi-Trump summit. The five-person delegation led by Republican Senator Steve Daines reportedly visited Beijing and Shanghai. The delegation is purportedly interested in better understanding China’s technological innovation and infrastructure, including its high-speed rail network.

Estimated nuclear warhead inventories, 2024-25

The Countries Armed With Nuclear Weapons

Estimated nuclear warhead inventories (as of Jan. 2025)*



* Deployed warheads as well as warheads in central storage. Excludes retired warheads
Source: SIPRI



Source: Statista



Other key events, issues and themes to watch in **May 2026**

Listed in chronological order



European Political Community Summit (4 May)

The summit will likely cover issues including energy security, defense, technology cooperation, and the conflicts in Iran and Ukraine. The European Political Community was established in the wake of the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022, with the goal of bolstering Europe-wide geopolitical cooperation. The group currently has 47 members, including non-EU members such as Türkiye, Armenia and Azerbaijan. The 4 May summit will take place in the Armenian capital Yerevan.

EU Economic and Financial Affairs Council meeting (5 May)

The meeting of the EU's financial and economic ministers will cover topics including the economic impacts of the Russian invasion of Ukraine, European economic recovery and tax fraud. The council will also hold a debate on the market integration and supervision package – a series of measures intended to strengthen the integration and efficiency of the EU's financial system.

Elections in the UK (7 May)

The elections could see a realignment in voter preferences toward the Reform and Green parties. In **England**, local elections will see more than 5,000 council seats up for grabs, as well as six directly elected mayoral posts. Recent polls suggest a surge in support for the Reform Party – which is among other policies advocating for tighter immigration curbs and lower taxation – and the Green Party. Labour and the Conservatives are facing significant seat losses.

Polls ahead of **Scotland's** parliamentary election on the same day indicate a lead for the ruling pro-independence Scottish National Party, with Labour and Reform virtually tied for second place. The Conservative Party – which came in second with almost a fifth of all votes in 2021 – could see its support halved.

For the legislative election in **Wales**, polls suggest support for the ruling Labour party could almost halve, with Reform and pro-independence Plaid Cymru nearly tied for first place, each with around 25%-29% of the projected vote.



Source: [Guillaume Périgois on Unsplash](#)

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ASEAN Leaders' Summit in the Philippines (8-9 May)

The Iran crisis and its economic impacts on Southeast Asia – which include inflationary pressure, rising fiscal burdens due to energy subsidies, and jet fuel shortages – are expected to dominate discussions. Talks will also likely focus on the war's implications for energy, food prices, and for the region's large expatriate community in the Middle East, as well as critical minerals, and the South China Sea Code of Conduct.

EU foreign and defence ministers' meetings (11-12 May)

The session is expected to include discussions on the EU's response to the war in the Middle East and the management of any knock-on implications of the conflict for the EU's support for Ukraine. Ministers will also discuss inputs into the development of the upcoming European Security Strategy.

Kevin Warsh's expected confirmation as new Fed Chair (mid-May)

The US Senate is expected to confirm the nomination of Kevin Warsh as the new Chairman of the Board of Governors of the US Federal Reserve. The vote will likely be scheduled during the first half of May. Current US Fed Chair Jay Powell's term as Chair expires on 15 May, by which point Trump administration officials and Senate Republicans are likely to push for Warsh's confirmation to be complete. If confirmed, Warsh's first FOMC meeting will take place on 16-17 June.

Russian President Putin to visit China (mid-May)

Putin's visit to China will likely seek to cement the China-Russia partnership (including more energy supplies for Beijing) and coordinate US policies after the Xi-Trump summit. Media reports indicate Putin could visit during the week of 18 May. The timing could suggest an exchange of views with China on the outcomes of the Xi-Trump summit, and an effort to coordinate policies toward Washington. Putin and Xi could also seek to deepen diplomatic and security ties, and coordinate on the Iran conflict, given Tehran's status as both countries' close partner.

For Beijing, securing increased Russian energy imports may be another objective. Russia's Foreign Minister Lavrov stated on 15 April that Moscow is willing to boost exports to China. The supply of Russian crude already rose by a [reported](#) 31% y/y during 2026-Q1.



Source: [Rafik Wahba on Unsplash](#)

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Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi expected to visit Europe and the UAE (15-20 May)

The expected visit to Italy, Norway, Sweden, and the Netherlands will likely seek to further strengthen trade and investment ties. This will include attendance at the India-Nordic Summit on 15 May. Talks will likely cover issues including energy, technological cooperation and defence, with the goal of deepening strategic cooperation as India pursues economic and trade diversification amid the ongoing global energy shock. Reports suggest Modi's itinerary could include a stop in the United Arab Emirates – India's key Gulf partner – for talks on topics including regional security and energy cooperation.

India to host BRICS (14-15 May) and Quad (late May) foreign ministers' meetings

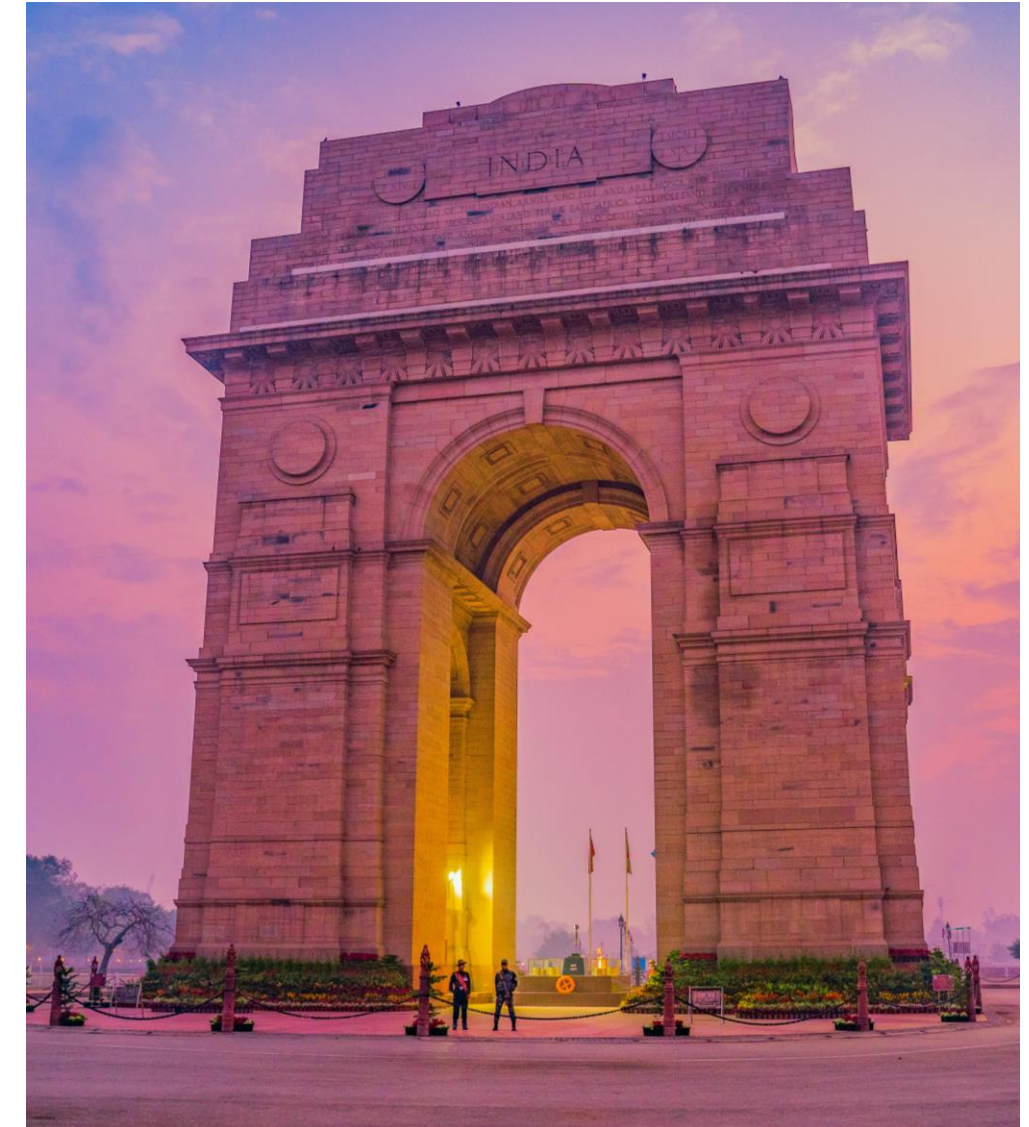
The hosting of two geopolitically competing meetings reflects new Delhi's multi-aligned policy approach. Marco Rubio's visit to India will reportedly be accompanied by the first meeting of the **Quad** group of countries (India, US, Japan and Australia) since July 2025. The Quad intends to bolster cooperation in areas including maritime security, infrastructure resilience, and emerging technologies.

New Delhi will also host a meeting of the **BRICS** foreign ministers, with talks expected to lay the groundwork for the BRICS Leaders Summit in India in September. While the meeting could address the Iran war, BRICS is unlikely to adopt a coordinated response to the crisis given members' diverging views on the issue. But as we have argued, the absence of a BRICS consensus on a geopolitical issue is not unusual. It should not be interpreted as either a setback for the organisation or as a potential point of fracture (see [Thematic Research: Geopolitical Crossroads: India's Strategic Balancing Act](#)).

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio to visit India (late May)

Rubio's India visit is expected to include talks on trade, critical minerals and energy. The visit will follow in the wake of the latest round of India-US trade talks in Washington in late April. Both sides are reportedly close to finalising the trade framework agreement from early February.

Rubio's visit and the ongoing trade talks reaffirm our view that India-US ties remain largely on track despite recent trade friction. This is due to a convergence of interests, including around long-term economic cooperation and shoring up India's position as an investment and manufacturing alternative to China ([Thematic Research: The US-India Bargain: Tariffs and Geopolitical Alignment](#)).



Source: [Swapnil Bapat](#) on [Unsplash](#)

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Shangri-La Dialogue defence summit in Singapore (29-31 May)

Singapore will host the annual Shangri-La Dialogue defence summit from 29-31 May. The event will bring together military and government officials from across the Asia Pacific and outside the region. The event can provide insights into how countries such as China and the US intend to approach major geopolitical challenges, including second-order security impacts from the Iran war.

Presidential election in Colombia; first round (31 May)

Colombia will hold the first round of its presidential elections on 31 May. A second round, if no candidate secures more than 50% of the vote, is expected and scheduled for 21 June.

Left-wing candidate Iván Cepeda is currently leading in most polls, with a tight race expected between two centre-right/right candidates, Paloma Valencia and Abelardo de la Espriella, who are competing for a position in the second-round runoff.



Source: [Random Institute](#) on [Unsplash](#)

Appendix 1



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